CA/Browser Forum Tracker

Part 3 - S/MIME Working Group

Compiled by the Spaced Research Ledger

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The S/MIME Working Group writes the rules for certificates that sign and encrypt email. Its Baseline Requirements are the youngest of the Forum's documents, adopted at the start of 2023, and the group has issued fifteen revisions since. Section 1 covers the current requirements and the version history behind them. Section 2 covers the RSA key size transition, whose first deadline falls two weeks after this report.

This group deserves more attention than its size suggests. It has already published post-quantum algorithms into its requirements, which the larger server certificate group has not. It is the clearest case in the Forum of a working group moving ahead of its bigger sibling.

1. Requirements and Version History

The version table is the record of what this group has agreed. Reading it in order shows a group that imports the server group's decisions deliberately rather than automatically.

Recent Developments

The current version is 1.0.15, published on 30 July 2026 by Ballot SMC017, titled Increase Minimum RSA CA Key Size [1] [2]. Version 1.0.14 followed on 5 May 2026 from Ballot SMC016, titled Equivalence with Ballots SC096 and SC097 [3]. That title is worth reading closely. It is this group importing the server group's DNSSEC logging carve-out and SHA-1 sunset by explicit decision, one ballot at a time.

Version 1.0.13 arrived on 27 March 2026 from Ballot SMC015, which allows a mobile driving licence to be used for authentication of individual identity [3]. Version 1.0.12 came on 13 October 2025 from Ballot SMC014, covering DNSSEC for CAA [3].

One ballot is adopted and awaiting publication. Ballot SMC018, titled Realignment of Multipurpose use cases, was posted on 11 August 2026 and is in its 30-day intellectual property review, having passed its vote [4].

Current State

Post-quantum algorithms are already permitted in this group's published requirements. Ballot SMC013, titled Introduction of PQC Algorithms, was published on 22 August 2025 as version 1.0.11 [5]. The S/MIME Baseline Requirements have therefore admitted post-quantum algorithms for over a year, while the equivalent text for web server certificates remains an unmerged draft.

The document's own starting point is recent. Version 1.0.0 was adopted on 1 January 2023 by Ballot SMC01, with an implementation deadline of 1 September 2023 [3].

Unresolved Conflicts

What SMC013 actually permits is not established here. The version table records that post-quantum algorithms were introduced, and gives the ballot and the date. The ballot text itself was not read. This report therefore cannot say which algorithms are allowed, in which positions of the certificate profile, or under what conditions.

Reading the ballot would settle it. Until then the safe reading is that the door is open in this group and shut in the server certificate group, without a precise account of how far open.

2. The RSA Key Size Transition

This is the group's most consequential current change, and its first deadline is imminent.

Current State

A new root or subordinate certificate authority RSA key must be at least 4096 bits, with a compliance date of 15 September 2026 [6]. The increase applies to certificate authority keys only. The minimum for subscriber certificates stays at 2048 bits [7].

The second stage closes the path for legacy keys without forcing their immediate removal. From 15 September 2027, certificate authorities may not issue subscriber certificates from any subordinate authority whose RSA modulus is smaller than 3072 bits [8]. Existing 2048-bit subordinate authorities are not revoked by that rule. They simply stop being able to issue, which lets them age out as their own certificates expire.

About This Report

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Sources

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2. Ballot SMC017v2, Increase Minimum RSA CA Key Size — CA/Browser Forum. https://cabforum.org/working-groups/smime/requirements/ (2026-07-30)
3. S/MIME Baseline Requirements version history — CA/Browser Forum. https://cabforum.org/working-groups/smime/requirements/ (2026-09-01)
4. Ballot SMC018, Realignment of Multipurpose use cases — CA/Browser Forum. https://cabforum.org/working-groups/smime/ (2026-08-11)
5. Ballot SMC013, Introduction of PQC Algorithms — CA/Browser Forum. https://cabforum.org/working-groups/smime/requirements/ (2025-08-22)

6. S/MIME Baseline Requirements, RSA CA key size requirement — CA/Browser Forum. https://cabforum.org/working-groups/smime/requirements/ (2026-09-15)
7. S/MIME Baseline Requirements, subscriber key size — CA/Browser Forum. https://cabforum.org/working-groups/smime/requirements/ (2026-07-30)
8. S/MIME Baseline Requirements, subordinate CA issuance sunset — CA/Browser Forum. https://cabforum.org/working-groups/smime/requirements/ (2027-09-15)